

GLOBAL DATA, 2023

The Global Burden of Mental Illness: Prevalence, Impact, & the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

Source: Our World in Data / IHME

PREVALENCE

Hundreds of Millions Affected: Major Depression

1 in 3

Women

will experience major depression in their lifetime.

1 in 5

Men

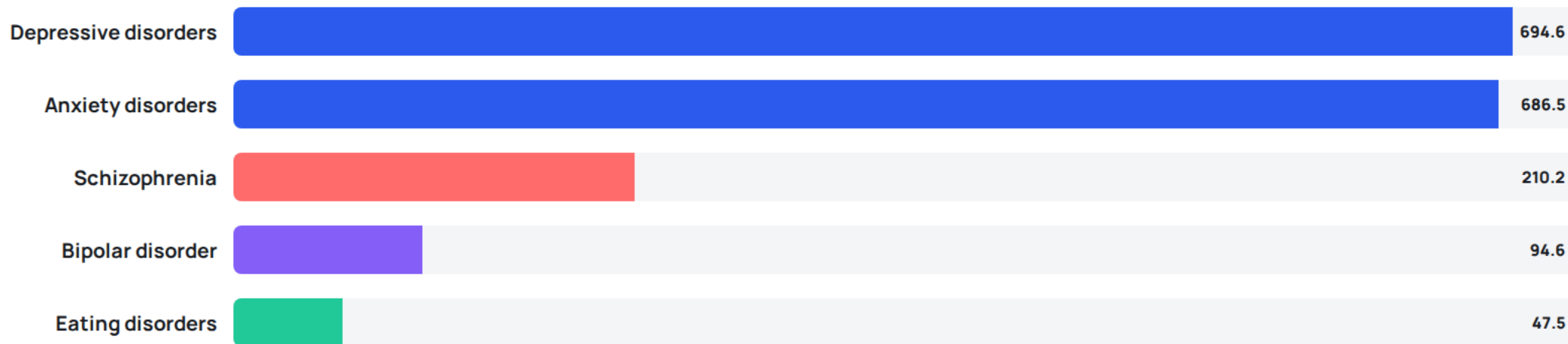
will experience major depression in their lifetime.

Mental health conditions span from highly common disorders like depression and anxiety to less common but severe conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder.

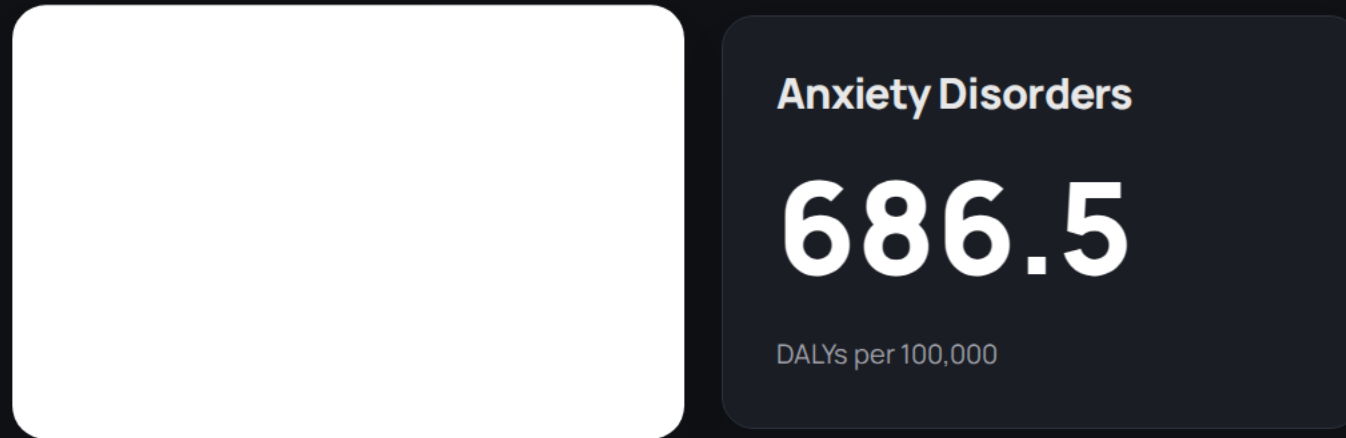
DISEASE BURDEN

Depression and Anxiety Dominate

Disability-adjusted life years (DALYs) per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



Combined, they account for roughly **80%** of the total mental health disease burden across the five main categories, dwarfing all other conditions at the population level.

SEVERITY VS. PREVALENCE

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder

Lower population prevalence, but severe individual impact.

- Schizophrenia affects fewer people but contributes a massive **210.2 DALYs** per 100,000.
- This disproportionately high burden reflects the severe disability associated with the condition.
- Bipolar disorder contributes smaller but meaningful shares (94.6 DALYs).

SCHIZOPHRENIA BURDEN

210.2

DALYs per 100k, reflecting intense individual disability relative to population count.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



Stigma

Many feel uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or family, leading to silence.



Access Limits

Treatment is critically lacking in low- and middle-income countries, and often of poor quality where it exists.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes estimating true prevalence difficult. The actual burden is likely far higher.

How People Cope Worldwide

Responses to mental health conditions vary widely, shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors.

Medication

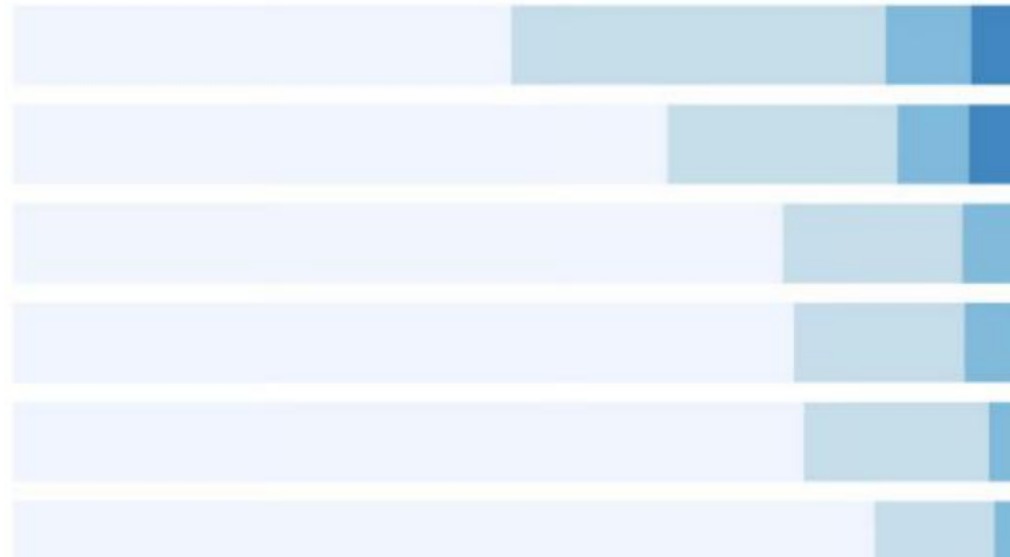
Taking prescribed medication is a highly common coping strategy in higher-income settings.

Faith & Spirituality

Engaging in religious or spiritual activities is prevalent in many regions worldwide.

Social Support

Talking to friends or family remains a universally reported and vital coping mechanism.



Key Takeaways for Program Planners

1

Prioritize the Burden of Common Disorders

Depression and anxiety represent roughly 80% of mental health DALYs. Scaling interventions here has the largest population impact.

2

Maintain Specialized Care for Severe Conditions

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden and require robust specialized systems.

3

Aggressively Target the Treatment Gap

Treatment exists but access and quality remain vastly inadequate globally. Combating stigma is crucial to accurate data and help-seeking.